

Justice lives *here*.

Montana is larger than Germany and has exactly one provider of free civil legal services. The whole strategy is already sitting in your tagline. It is the last word.

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS

A directional concept, made before I have met your staff, your board or your clients. It is not a finished identity and it should not be. It exists so you can see how I think about your problem before you decide whether to shortlist me.

Everything here is the opening of a conversation, not an answer waiting for approval. Where I am uncertain, I have said so rather than smoothing it over.

SERVING MONTANA	COUNTIES COVERED	TRIBAL RESERVATIONS	PROVIDERS
60+ years	All 56	All	One

What you asked for

Your RFP asks that each requirement be restated before it is answered. This is that list, read back to you, so you can check I have understood the brief before you read a single opinion of mine.

Submission

hshaw@mtlsa.org, subject line “Rebrand Vendor for Montana Legal Services Association”

5:00 PM MST, 14 SEP 2026

Format

Ten pages maximum. Each requirement restated before it is answered. Late submissions automatically disqualified.

10 PP

Term

Kickoff through delivery, running across two fiscal years.

26 OCT 26 – 30 JUN 27

Budget

Inclusive of brand strategy, identity, collateral and the website rebuild.

\$25–30K

Brand

Logo, colour palette, typography, logo usage guidelines, imagery guidelines, brand style guide, PowerPoint template, business card, letterhead banner, tagline, positioning statement, key messages, storytelling options, renaming analysis.

14 ITEMS

Website

Design and build, CMS as needed, content migration, site search, Spanish language support, accessibility implementation, QA, browser testing, staff documentation, editor training.

10 ITEMS

Audiences

Potential clients, funders, donors, community partners, and the Montana legal community.

5 GROUPS

Facilitation

Structured conversations with management, staff, board members, clients and community partners.

WEIGHTED

02 / POSITIONING STATEMENT

Your brand has two jobs that pull against each other

A woman with seven days to answer an eviction complaint needs to find one thing, quickly, on a phone, possibly on one bar of signal, possibly on a library computer with a queue behind her.

A program officer at a foundation needs to see a sixty-year-old institution that can be trusted with a grant.

Most legal aid brands solve the second job and hope the first takes care of itself. That is why so many of them end up looking like law firms: navy, columns, a serif in small caps. It reassures the funder, and it quietly tells the client that this place is not for them.

This concept solves the first job, and argues that solving it properly is the most convincing thing you can show the second.

One observation, offered carefully. Today the first thing on your homepage is a notice about reduced staffing capacity. It is honest and it is necessary information.

It is also the first sentence a person in crisis reads, and in that position it reads as a closed door.

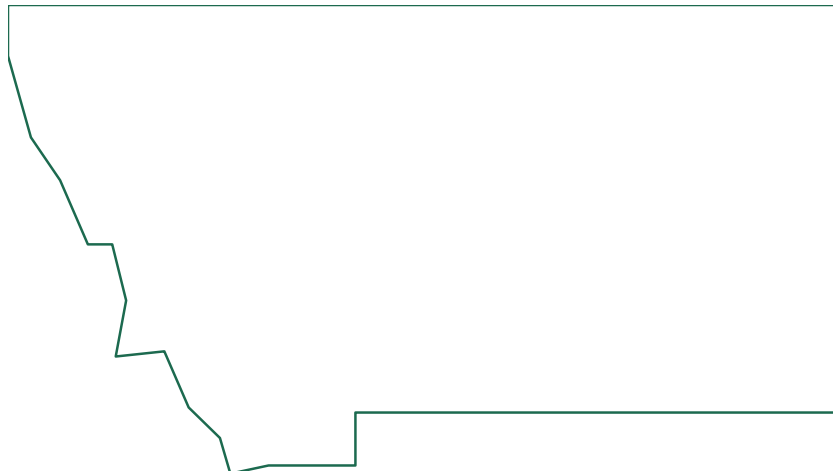
I do not think that is a copywriting problem. It is a structural one: there is nowhere else on the site for urgent operational news to live, so it goes on top of everything. A rebuild can give it a proper home, one that sets expectations honestly without turning people away at the threshold.

Keep the tagline. Make the identity earn it.

Justice Lives Here is a better line than most rebrands produce. I would not replace it. I would build everything else around the word the line is actually resting on.

Here is doing the work. Montana is larger than Germany. It has 56 counties and every tribal reservation in the state, and one organisation covering all of them. For someone in Plentywood, or on Fort Peck, *here* is not a figure of speech. It is the claim that the only civil legal aid in Montana reaches them too.

So the identity should be built on place and reach. Not on legal iconography. **No scales, no gavel, no columns.** Those symbols describe the courthouse, and your clients are usually trying not to end up in one.



147,040 SQ MI / ONE PROVIDER

You may not have a naming problem. You may have an architecture problem.

A

THE CASE FOR RENAMING

Montana Legal Services Association is four words, three of them institutional. It describes a structure rather than a promise, and Association in particular reads as a trade body rather than a law firm for people who cannot afford one.

B

THE CASE AGAINST

Sixty years of recognition with the Montana bar, with funders, and on court filings. That equity is real. But it is not evenly distributed: the lawyers know exactly who you are. Many of the people you exist for have never heard the name.

C

WHERE I WOULD START

Keep the legal name for courts, funders and the bar, where the equity lives. Lead publicly with a short service name a person in trouble can say out loud and remember. One organisation, two registers.

That is a starting position and I expect it to change once I have sat with your board. What matters more is the structural consequence: **whatever is decided, the identity has to survive it.** Every mark in the next section is drawn to work without words beside it, and Route C is built so the name can be swapped without redrawing a single curve.

Three routes, shown where marks usually fall apart

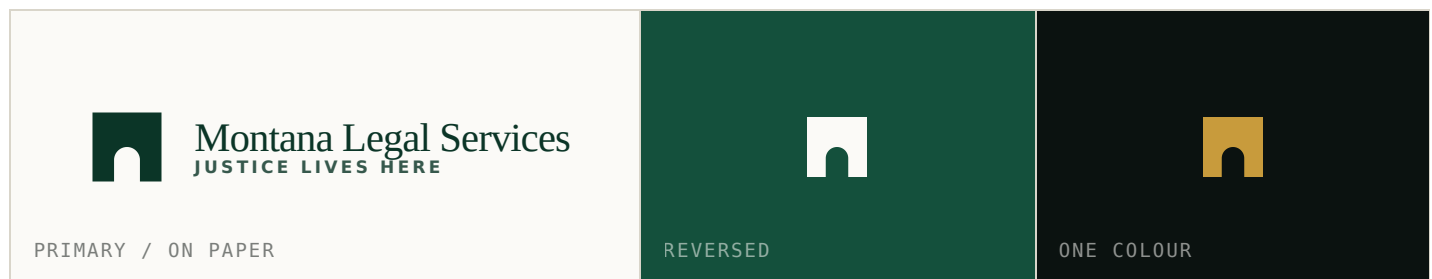
Any mark looks fine at 400 pixels on a white slide. These are shown reversed, in one colour, and at favicon size, because that is where the difference between a drawing and an identity shows up.

ROUTE A

The Open Door

Montana is one of a handful of states a person can draw from memory, because it is very nearly a rectangle. Cut a doorway into the bottom edge and the state itself becomes the way in. It says what the tagline says without a word of explanation, and it still reads at sixteen pixels.

Strongest concept. Needs care at very small sizes so the doorway does not fill in.



ROUTE B

First Light

Big Sky is not decoration in Montana, it is the actual ratio of the place: a very low horizon under an enormous amount of sky. Land solid, sky open, and a vertical that is a person standing on it. This is the warmest of the three.

Also the least distinctive. Circles with horizons are common in nonprofit identity, and I would say so in the room rather than after you had chosen it.



Montana Legal Services
JUSTICE LIVES HERE

PRIMARY / ON PAPER



REVERSED



ONE COLOUR

LEGIBILITY AT SIZE



16PX



24PX



32PX



48PX

ROUTE C

The Level

The oldest instrument for checking whether a thing is true is a level. Here the arm of the L runs out to become a baseline, and the bubble comes to rest on it. It is the cheapest of the three to reproduce and the most robust at small sizes.

The only route that survives a rename with no redrawing at all, which matters given the renaming analysis you asked for.



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REVERSED



ONE COLOUR

LEGIBILITY AT SIZE



16PX



24PX



32PX



48PX

06 / COLOUR PALETTE

Measured, not chosen by eye

Every ratio below was computed against the paper ground, not estimated. One of them fails, and it is still in the palette, because the useful thing is not a palette where everything passes. It is a palette that tells your team exactly where each colour is allowed to go.

Lodgepole	Lodgepole Deep
#14503C 8.97:1 AA Primary. Headlines, primary buttons, the brand block.	#0B3527 12.96:1 AA Body text on light, and the ground for reversed lockups.
Glacier	Badlands
#1D5D72 7.03:1 AA Secondary. Links, informational states, section accents.	#A6431A 5.85:1 AA Semantic only. Deadlines, court dates, anything time-critical.
Badlands Light	Wheat
#D4744A 3.15:1 FAILS The dark-ground counterpart to Badlands. Same semantic role, inverted ground.	#C89B3C 2.45:1 FAILS Dark grounds only. Fails on paper, so the guide forbids it there.

Wheat Deep	Ink
#8A6412 5.14:1 AA The light-ground substitute for Wheat. Same role, legal contrast.	#111815 17.26:1 AA Running text. A green-biased black, not a borrowed neutral.
Paper #FBFAF7 Ground. Warm enough to soften glare, cool enough to stay legal.	

Wheat is the useful example. At 2.45:1 on paper it is illegal for text, and a designer who did not check would use it for a heading and never know. So the guide does not present it as a colour with a warning attached. It presents Wheat as a dark-ground colour and Wheat Deep as its light-ground equivalent, and the mistake becomes impossible to make rather than merely discouraged.

Badlands needed the same treatment, and I found that out the way you are supposed to: **an automated contrast audit of this page failed it.** The rust that is legible on paper is not legible on a dark ground, so it has a counterpart too. Two of the seven colours here carry a ground restriction, and both restrictions are in the palette rather than in somebody's memory.

Three faces, no licence fees, ever

DISPLAY
NEWSREADER

Justice lives here

INTERFACE
PUBLIC SANS

Apply for legal help

You have 7 days to respond to an eviction complaint in Montana.

DATA
IBM PLEX MONO

Case 24-DV-0917 / filed 08.14.2026

Public Sans is the typeface of the US Web Design System, drawn for government services that have to be readable by everyone who is entitled to use them. For a legal aid organisation that is not a neutral pick. It is an argument, and it is one your funders will recognise.

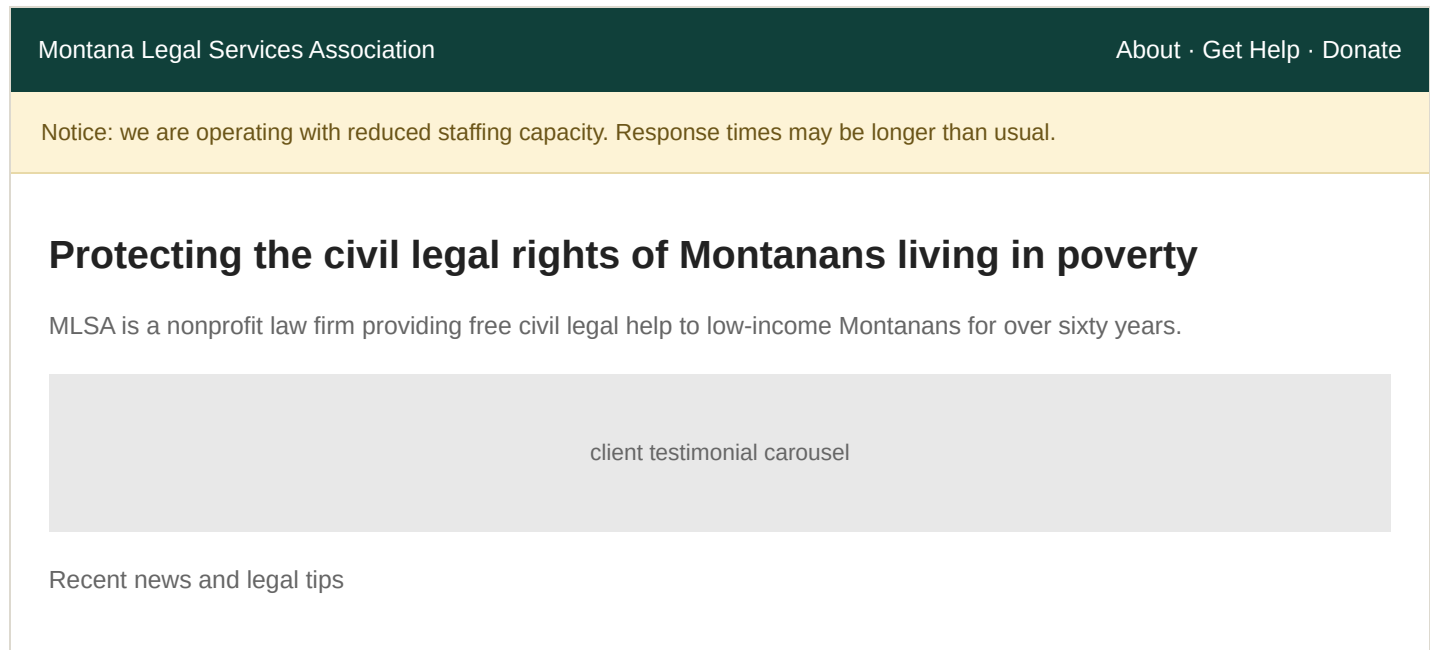
Newsreader carries the sixty years. It gives headlines dignity without the small-caps-and-columns costume that makes legal aid look like the opposition.

All three faces are open source. **MLSA never pays a licence fee, and never has to ask a vendor for permission to set its own name.** Over an eight month project that is a small thing. Over the next decade it is not.

Open with what is wrong, not with who you are

A person arrives at a legal aid website in the middle of the worst week of their year. They are not browsing. They have one question, and the homepage should be built to answer it in a single tap.

● TODAY





[Get help](#)
[Legal info](#)
[Español](#)

[Leave this site](#)

FREE LEGAL HELP, EVERY COUNTY IN MONTANA

What is happening to you?

Choose the one closest to your situation. It takes about four minutes.

I am being evicted

Housing

I am not safe at home

Protection orders

My benefits stopped

Public benefits

I am being sued for a debt

Consumer

56

counties served

All

tribal reservations

60+

years in Montana

The first two things a frightened person reads are an apology about capacity and a mission statement written for a grant application. Help is four words into a navigation bar.

Four doors, in the words people actually use about their own lives. Not *Housing Law*. **I am being evicted.**

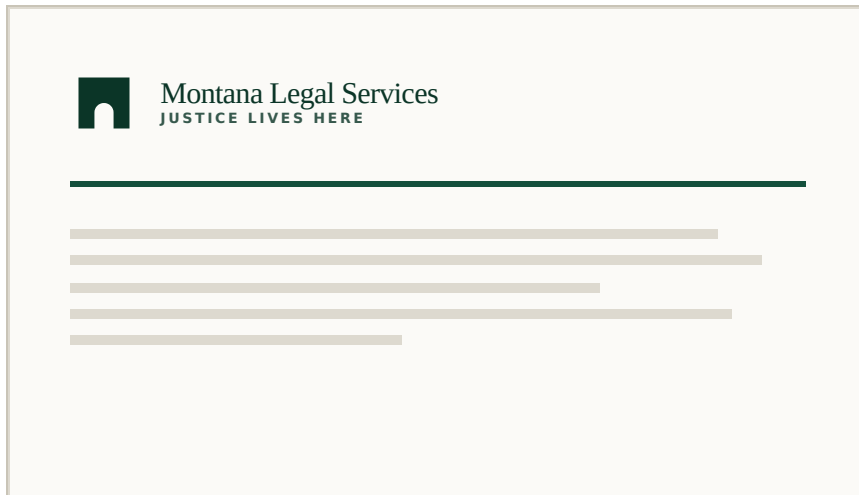
Three details worth noticing. *Español* sits in the main navigation rather than behind a flag icon. *Leave this site* is in the top right, standard practice for any service used by people fleeing violence. And the credibility numbers still appear, immediately below the help, where they reassure the funder without blocking the client.

The system, applied

● BUSINESS CARD



● LETTERHEAD BANNER



● PRESENTATION TEMPLATE



In 2026 we closed 4,100 cases
with 22 attorneys.

Board report / Q4

Justice Lives Here

Figures on this slide are placeholders, included only to show the template. I have not been given your case numbers and I have not guessed at them.

The part I would not let you buy from anyone else

WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU RENEW

Your site currently runs an accessibility overlay widget. In January 2025 the Federal Trade Commission ordered accessiBe, the largest vendor in that category, to pay **\$1 million** over deceptive claims that its AI product could make websites compliant with accessibility guidelines. The final order was approved in April 2025.

ftc.gov, January 2025 (<https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2025/01/ftc-order-requires-online-marketer-pay-1-million-deceptive-claims-its-ai-product-could-make-websites>)

I am not raising this to score a point off a decision someone made in good faith. **You installed it because you care about the thing it promised**, which is exactly right for an organisation whose clients disproportionately live with disabilities.

The problem is that the promise was not kept, and a rebuild is the moment to replace it with the real version: accessibility written into the markup, tested with an actual screen reader, measured against WCAG 2.1 AA, and documented so your editors do not undo it in month three.

There is a second half to this that branding studios rarely raise. For your clients, bandwidth is an accessibility requirement. A site that quietly assumes a good connection excludes rural Montana and much of the reservation land you serve, and it does it invisibly, because those people simply never arrive.

So this page is the argument as well as the description of it. It is built on the same stack I would build your site on, and it is designed to be read on a bad connection.

THIS PAGE, MEASURED	
Total page weight	58KB
JavaScript required to read it	None
Contrast ratios computed, not estimated	All
Renders without a stylesheet	Yes
Turn JavaScript off and reload. Nothing here disappears. That is the standard I would hold your site to.	

11 / SCHEDULE AND FACILITATION

October to June, in seven phases

Phase 0

Listening

Structured sessions with management, staff, board, clients and community partners. Client conversations run separately from funder conversations, because the two groups cannot say what they actually think in the same room.

Oct – Nov

Phase 1

Strategy and naming

Positioning, key messages, storytelling framework, and the renaming analysis with a written recommendation your board can vote on.

Nov – Dec

Phase 2

Identity

Three routes developed properly, one chosen, then drawn out into a full system.

Dec – Jan

Phase 3

Guide and collateral

Brand style guide, logo usage and imagery guidelines, PowerPoint template, business card, letterhead banner.

Jan – Feb

Phase 4

Website design

Information architecture, the problem-led homepage, templates, Spanish language structure, and design review.

Feb – Mar

Phase 5

Build and migration

Front end, CMS, content migration from the existing site, site search.

Mar – May

Phase 6

Accessibility, training, launch

WCAG 2.1 AA audit with assistive technology, browser and device testing, staff documentation, editor training, launch and hand-over.

May – Jun

On facilitation, the honest note. I work from India. Montana is eleven and a half hours behind me for most of your project, twelve and a half after the clocks change.

The way I run this is that sessions happen in your morning, which is my evening, and the write-up is in your inbox before your next working day starts. What you get in exchange for the time zone is that the work moves while your office is closed.

One structural request. Client conversations should be held separately from funder and board conversations. Not for convenience: people who have needed legal aid will not say what they actually think about your brand while the people who fund it are in the room.

That separation is the difference between research and a focus group that agrees with whoever spoke first.

What I have not done here

I have not talked to a single one of your clients, and everything above is therefore a hypothesis. I have not seen your analytics, your intake numbers or the content inventory behind the site. The renaming position is a starting point, not a recommendation I would defend before I had heard your board disagree with it.

What this does show is how I work: read the brief closely, look at the real site, measure rather than assert, and say the uncomfortable thing early rather than in month five.

If that is the working relationship you want, the full proposal follows the format your RFP asks for, within the ten pages, before the deadline.

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Directional concept
Not a finished identity
August 2026